SAMPLE

# Madyan: The Land of Shu'ayb

Madyan (مدين) in the Quran

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## Introduction

The Quran tells the story of a land of merchants -- a people whose trade made them prosperous and whose prosperity made them corrupt. The land is Madyan, and the prophet sent to it was Shu'ayb. The Quran says:

"And to Madyan [We sent] their brother Shu'ayb. He said: O my people, worship Allah. You have no deity other than Him" (7:85).

Madyan is the land of the market. Unlike 'Aad, whose sin was arrogance, or the people of Nuh, whose sin was rejection, the people of Madyan sinned in their commerce -- they cheated in their weights and measures, they deprived people of their due, and they corrupted the trade that was the source of their wealth. The prophet who was sent to them was the prophet who called them to honesty: "Give full measure and do not be of those who cause loss" (26:181). The call was the confrontation: the people who defined themselves by their trade were told that their trade was corrupt.

The destruction of Madyan came by the earthquake. The Quran says: "So the earthquake seized them, and they became in their homes ones fallen on their faces" (7:91). The earth that was the foundation of their trade -- the land that supported their markets and their roads -- was the earth that shook and destroyed them. The earthquake is the significance: the people who trusted in the stability of the earth were destroyed by the instability of the earth. The ground that they thought was solid was the ground that opened and swallowed them.

This book -- the seventh in the Places in the Qur'an series -- covers Madyan: its name, its people, its prophet, its message of honest trade, its rejection, its earthquake, its thicket, and its connections to the other sacred places. The book follows the same approach as the first six books -- Makkah: The Holy City, Madinah: The City of the Prophet, Al-Quds: The Night Journey, Egypt: The Land of Pharaoh, Mount Judi: The Resting Place, and Iram: The Lost City -- exploring the place as the Quran presents it.

The Places in the Qur'an series traces the sacred geography of the Quran. The first book explored Makkah -- the center of worship. The second book explored Madinah -- the center of community. The third book explored Jerusalem -- the center of the prophets. The fourth book explored Egypt -- the center of trial. The fifth book explored Mount Judi -- the center of survival. The sixth book explored Iram -- the center of transience. This seventh book explores Madyan -- the center of commerce. The seven places are the seven dimensions of the sacred geography: the House, the community, the tradition, the test, the survival, the transience, and the commerce. The person who understands the seven understands that the places where Allah acted are the places that teach -- and the land where the trade was corrupted is the land that teaches that even the market is under the authority of the divine.

Madyan is the seventh pillar of the sacred geography -- the pillar that teaches that the trade that is not honest is the trade that is destroyed, and the wealth that is not earned with justice is the wealth that is taken by the earthquake.

## Chapter 1: The Name -- Madyan in the Quran

The Quran mentions Madyan by name in several passages:

"And to Madyan [We sent] their brother Shu'ayb" (7:85).

"And to Madyan [We sent] their brother Shu'ayb" (11:84).

"And to Madyan [We sent] their brother Shu'ayb, but they denied him" (29:36).

The name is the significance: Madyan is the name of the place -- the land or the people -- that received the prophet Shu'ayb. The Quran names the place because the place is real. The naming is the authenticity: the book that names the land is the book that is grounded in the geography of the earth. The naming is the lesson: the land that is named is the land that is remembered, and the land that is remembered is the land that teaches. The person who reads the name and does not learn the lesson has read the name without understanding the significance.

The name "Madyan" (مدين) is traditionally associated with the people of Madyan, a trading community that lived in the region northwest of the Arabian Peninsula -- near the Gulf of Aqaba, in the area associated with the biblical Midian. The name is the identity: the people who are called Madyan are the people who are known by their land, and the land that is called Madyan is the land that is known by its people. The name is the lesson: the people and the place are inseparable. The people who corrupted the trade corrupted the land, and the land that was corrupted was the land that was destroyed.

The Quran uses the name Madyan for both the people and the place. The dual usage is the significance: the people and the place are one -- the people who are the merchants are the people who are the land, and the land that is the market is the land that is the people. The dual usage is the lesson: the person and the place are connected. The people who corrupt the trade corrupt the place, and the place that is corrupted by the people is the place that is destroyed for the people. The person who is part of a corrupt community is the person who is part of a place that is destined for destruction.

The Quran does not specify the exact location of Madyan. Traditionally, Madyan is identified with the region of northwestern Arabia, near the Gulf of Aqaba -- a region that was strategically located on the trade routes between Arabia, Egypt, and the Levant. The location is the significance: the people who lived on the trade routes were the people who depended on the trade. The location is the lesson: the trade that was the source of the wealth was the trade that was the source of the corruption. The people who lived where the trade passed through were the people who were tempted to take advantage of the trade -- and the people who took advantage were the people who were destroyed.

Madyan was located on the trade routes that connected the ancient world -- the routes that carried goods between Egypt, Arabia, and the Levant. The connection is the significance: the people who lived on the trade routes were the people who were in a position to profit from the trade -- and to cheat in the trade. The connection is the lesson: the position of the advantage is the position of the test. The people who are in a position to profit are the people who are tested by the profit. The trade route that was the source of the wealth was the trade route that was the source of the temptation, and the temptation that was not resisted was the corruption that was punished.

Madyan is remembered in the Quran as a warning. The Quran says:

"And the inhabitants of the thicket were indeed wrongdoers, so We took them with a seizure of might" (15:78-79).

The memory is the significance: the land that was destroyed is the land that is remembered -- not for its trade but for its destruction. The memory is the lesson: the person who remembers Madyan remembers the earthquake. The person who remembers the earthquake remembers the consequence of the corruption. The memory is the warning: the land that was the center of commerce became the center of the warning -- the warning that the trade without honesty is the trade that is destroyed, and the wealth without justice is the wealth that is taken by the earthquake.

The land of Madyan and the prophet Shu'ayb are inseparable in the Quran. The Quran always mentions them together: "To Madyan [We sent] their brother Shu'ayb" (7:85, 11:84, 29:36). The inseparability is the significance: the land is known by the prophet, and the prophet is known by the land. The inseparability is the lesson: the person and the place are connected. The prophet who is sent to a place is the prophet whose message is shaped by the place. The prophet who was sent to the merchants was the prophet whose message addressed the trade. The person who studies the land should study the prophet, and the person who studies the prophet should study the land -- because the two are one.